BOOKS

OUR COSMIC DOT

Raza: The Other Modern offers a well-rounded assessment of the art of Sayed Haider Raza

When Sayed Haider Raza arrived in Paris in 1952, aged 28, he carried deep within him the resonance of India, silent and cocooned. It was wrapped in many layers of colonisation and complexes that his Western art practice eventually gave him courage to unravel layer by layer, to arrive at a cerebral geometric abstraction for the world to sit back and take note of with awe.

The book under review is a companion volume to a recently concluded Raza retrospective, held in Dubai, a convergent city suspended between East and West. Seeking a balance between material realisation and its pestering, unfulfilled quest, the Progressive Art Gallery director Harshvardhan Singh calls Raza's artistic evolution "a testimony to his relentless pursuit of truth through colour and form".

Born in the forests of Babaria, MP, where his father was a forest ranger, as a child Raza had found the forest darkness rather hallucinatory, a place where sunrise would bring him security. The artist would go on to tame the free-flowing forms of nature into a rigid geometry, softened with colours. His use of the grim and dark colours of Europe in the 1970s finally lead to his most creative phase in the 1980s. With important works like 'Saurashtra' and 'Rajasthan', he stole the heart of the art world, and moved India deeply with his homesick work, '*Maa lautke jab aaonga, kya launga?* (Mother [India], when I come home, what will I bring?)'

Ashok Vajpeyi, who now heads the Raza Foundation, was to become Raza's comfort zone when, after 60 years in France, India's prodigious son finally returned home in 2010, just before his 89th birthday. Vajpeyi's comforting foreword ('Something That Will Live Longer') and epilogue ('The Last Days') to this handy Mapin book holds all the pictures and words like revered bookends

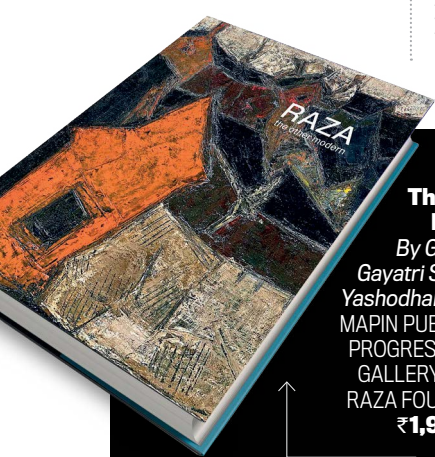
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offered to posterity. It was Vajpeyi who made a conducive atmosphere for Raza to create some 550 canvases and 80 drawings in his final five years back home in India.

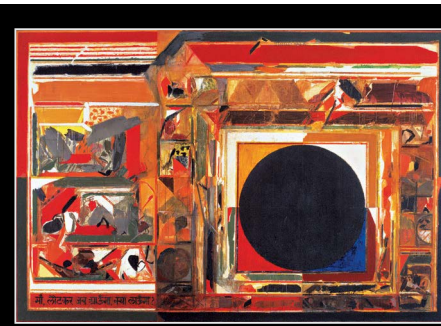
The book looks at 'the range, depth and complexity' of Raza's work as Vajpeyi tries to fathom this multi-faceted personality from all angles. The three graces—Geeti Sen, Gayatri Sinha and Yashodhara Dalmia—join in for this very rewarding decoding. Sen, the 'Raza bindu' specialist, talks more about the 'mystery and wonder' of Nature than the others do. Sinha looks beyond the east-west polarities to Raza's prismatic triangles, unearthing tripartite facets to the artist's life: first, his tri-lingual speech—Hindi, English, French; then to the expatriate triangle of friendships in Mumbai: Leyden, Langhammer, Schlesinger; as well as pointing out the three phases of abstraction which Raza's practice exhibits. Dalmia, with her strong, wise and stoic glance, decodes Raza's post-World War cities, painted flat as walls, where colours dig into their own depths to create their desired perspective, while light too seems to appear from within.

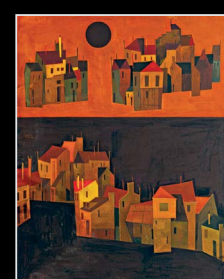
Raza's art made self-centering a visual, meditative journey where, if one cared, one could concentrate on concentric circles to zoom in, or out, and then also within. Raza's point was precisely this immersive dot, from which arises space, time, consciousness—both philosophically and materially. Since his passing, Raza has continued to glow and blaze in rainbow colours. Quite literally, he became our cosmic dot. ■

–Aman Nath



RAZA: The Other Modern
By Geeti Sen, Gayatri Sinha and Yashodhara Dalmia
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(From top right) Maa, 1981 (acrylic on canvas); The Artist (Somnath Bhat), 1948 (gouache on paper); Untitled, 1952 (gouache on paper)